

Homewise VOC Interview Notes #8

Before the interview (screener, done async or in first 2 min)

- Have you hired a contractor (plumber, electrician, HVAC, roofer, handyman, remodeler, etc. all count!) before?

Yes, I've hired plumbers before for rental apartment repairs.

- Roughly what did the project cost? (A range is fine. Ideally, we want a mix: small repairs, bigger projects)

Usually a few hundred dollars, depending on the issue.

- Do you own your home?

No, I'm currently renting.

Warm-up

1. Tell me a bit about your home — how long have you owned it, and how often do you find yourself needing to hire someone for projects or repairs?

I'm renting, so most repairs technically go through the landlord, but sometimes I need to find plumbers or repair people myself, especially for urgent issues or when the landlord wants me to coordinate directly.

The Recent Experience

Anchor everything on one specific recent hire. Don't let them generalize.

2. Walk me through the **last time** you hired a contractor. Start from the moment you realized you needed one.

Recently, I had a plumbing issue in my apartment where the kitchen sink started leaking and draining very slowly. Since it was affecting daily life, I needed to find a plumber quickly.

3. How did you find them? What sources did you use? (Let them list — don't prompt.)

I searched on Yelp and Google, and also asked friends for recommendations.

4. How did you decide which ones to contact? What made you rule some out?

I looked at reviews, response time, and whether they seemed professional. I ruled out companies with unclear pricing or poor customer feedback.

5. How many quotes did you get? How did you compare them?

I contacted several plumbers by phone. I mainly compared pricing, availability, and online reviews.

6. How did you know if the price was fair?

Honestly, I didn't really know. That was the most frustrating part. I had to make many phone calls just to compare prices, and pricing was very non-transparent. Different plumbers quoted very different amounts for what sounded like the same problem.

7. What did you do (if anything) to check if they were licensed, insured, or reputable?

I checked online reviews and asked whether they were licensed and insured.

8. Walk me through scheduling and the actual work — how did that go?

Scheduling was stressful because I needed to coordinate between my own schedule, the plumber's availability, and sometimes my landlord as well. The actual repair went okay once someone finally came.

9. After the work was done, what happened with paperwork, receipts, warranties?

I received a receipt afterward, but there wasn't much clarity around warranties or future support.

If you find someone trustworthy, would you hire them again?

Definitely. Once you find someone reliable and reasonably priced, you don't want to go through the search process again.

Do you want to refer the contractor to someone else?

Yes. Good plumbers are difficult to find, so referrals are very valuable.

Pain Point

10. What was the **most frustrating part** of that whole experience?

The most frustrating part was having to make many phone calls to compare prices while still not knowing whether the pricing was fair. The whole process lacked transparency, especially during an urgent repair situation.

11. If you could change one thing about hiring a contractor, what would it be?

I wish there were one platform that could instantly compare plumber pricing, availability, reviews, and licensing information in a transparent way, so I wouldn't need to spend hours calling different companies.

Current Workarounds & Prior Spending

12. Is there anything you do today to make hiring contractors easier — spreadsheets, apps, asking neighbors?

Mostly asking friends, neighbors, and checking online reviews. There's no really efficient system today.

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13. Have you ever paid for a service to help you find or vet contractors (Angi, Thumbtack, etc.)? What was that like?

I've looked at those platforms, but I still found pricing inconsistent and difficult to compare clearly.

Wrap-up

14. Looking back on that whole experience — finding, hiring, and working with the contractor — how would you describe it in a few words?

Stressful, time-consuming, and very non-transparent.

15. Is there anything about hiring contractors I didn't ask about that I should have?

You could ask more about pricing transparency, emergency repairs, and how difficult it is to judge whether a quote is reasonable.

16. Do you know 1–2 other homeowners who've hired contractors recently who might be open to a similar chat?

No.